

The California Berry Variety Picker

The variety decides more than the care does. In mild-winter California (zones 9b and 10a), winters deliver roughly 400 to 600 chill hours, so the whole game is picking varieties bred for that. Every plant below clears the bar. Take this page to the nursery.

Crop	Variety	Pick this if...
Strawberry	Albion	You want one dependable plant that fruits spring through fall. The default first pick
	Seascape	Your garden runs a little warmer; bred for California and starts early
	Chandler	You make jam and want one heavy spring flush instead of a trickle
Blueberry	Sunshine Blue	You are planting in a container, or buying only one bush (it is self-fertile)
	Misty	You want the first fruit of the year, ripening in May on the coast
	O'Neal	Flavor outranks everything and your winters run a bit cooler (400 to 500 chill hours)
Raspberry	Heritage	You want the reliable classic every nursery carries; fruits late summer into fall
	Joan J	You want thornless canes, an earlier start, and heavy yields
	Fall Gold	You eat berries in the garden, not from the fridge; sweet, soft, and yellow
Blackberry	Triple Crown	You have a fence or trellis and want the best all-around thornless berry
	Ouachita	You want a self-supporting row with no trellis to build; the beginner pick
	Baby Cakes	Your garden is a patio; full-size berries from a 10 to 15 gallon pot
	Prime-Ark Freedom	You are impatient: it fruits its very first fall, on new canes
Olallieberry	Olallieberry	You want the Santa Cruz pie berry and will trade thorns and a trellis for it

All blueberries listed are low-chill southern highbush. Raspberry picks are fall-bearing (primocane) types, the group suited to mild winters.

Three rules before you buy

- **Check the chill number, not the picture.** If the tag wants more than about 500 hours, a mild-winter garden cannot promise it.
- **Buy two blueberry varieties.** Most are only partly self-fertile; a partner within 50 feet means bigger, earlier crops.
- **Winter bare-root beats summer impulse.** December through February plants cost less and establish better.

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